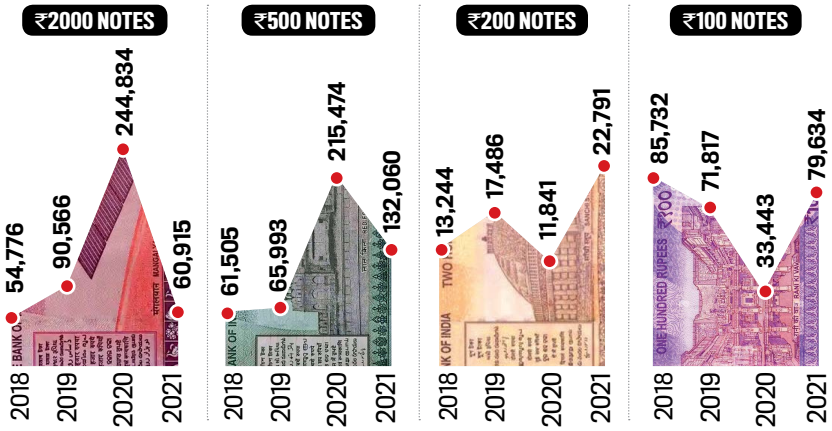
FAKE NOTE SEIZURES



*Source: NCRB; *No. of notes recovered*

The current trends in FICN production also suggest that the criminals are managing to stay one step ahead of the authorities. The recent RBI decision to pull the plug on the Rs 2,000 note is an example. A careful perusal of the trend in FICN seizures suggests it may not have much of an impact on the circulation of counterfeit notes as the forgers had shifted their focus to the Rs 500 note from the higher denomination back in 2021 itself. The latest available NCRB figures, from 2021, show that seizures of Rs 500 denomination fakes (132,060 notes) was more than double that of Rs 2,000 (60,915) ones. As for the quality of the notes, police sources say the notes seized in Bihar were "passable", but the Chennai unit's product was quite sophisticated.

The RBI issued a majority of the Rs 2,000 notes prior to March 2017, and since the denomination was already being used sparingly for transactions, the counterfeiters appear to have shifted their focus. The RBI decided to pull the plug on the pink currency in May 2023. The central bank's latest annual report, published on May 30 this year, further confirms the trend that the counterfeiters have shifted focus to the Rs 500 denomination note. It says the number of fake currency notes of Rs 500 denomination detected by the banking system more than doubled from 39,453 pieces in 2019-20 to 79,669 pieces in 2021-22 and 91,110 in the 2022-23 financial year. Though overall seizure figures in 2021 showed a downward trend (see *Fake Note Seizures*), police sources dismiss it as a blip in the rising graph of fake note seizures. "The dip in 2021 was just that, an anomaly in the graph. It does not mean the counterfeiters have been effectively controlled," says a senior IPS officer in Jharkhand.

The circulation of FICN in the country continues to pose a challenge even after the demonetisation exercise in 2016, a key objective of which, ironically, was to end counterfeit currency. The withdrawal of the Rs 2,000 note, too, is unlikely to have a 'cause and effect' impact on controlling the fake notes problem. Incidentally, the NCRB reports of successive years after 2016 suggest that FICN with a face value of Rs 245.3 crore has been seized by law enforcement agencies in the country. ■



By Dhaval Kulkarni

The crowded political arena in Maharashtra just got a little more so with Sambhajiraje Chhatrapati, the scion of the royal family of Kolhapur, announcing his intent to contest the Lok Sabha and state assembly elections due in 2024. He has converted his social organisation, 'Swarajya', into a political party of the same name. At a convention of his outfit in Pune on May 28, and amidst slogans like "*Maharashtra ka mukhyamantri kaisa ho? Sambhajiraje jaisa ho*", the ex-royal attacked the established political parties for retreating from sectors like education, public health and cooperatives. He promised to "give a different direction to society and Maharashtra".

This is the first time someone with a major royal connection in Maharashtra—Sambhajiraje is the 13th descendant of Chhatrapati Shivaji—is floating his own party. However, erstwhile royals and feudals like Udayanraje Bhosale and his cousin Shivendraraje Bhosale (both BJP), who represent the Satara branch of Shivaji's descendants,